# Mapping shifts in the geography of tech innovation: China becomes a big player in AI research

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Coco Feng October 5, 2025

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Published: 8:00am, 5 Oct 2025

The belief that China is a country only good at adopting technologies at scale has been a “misperception”, according to the author of *The New Geography of Innovation,* a recently published book that maps the rise of new tech powers around the world excluding the US.

“The geography of innovation is shifting”, the book, which came out in July, concluded. Covering tech start-ups across China, the UK, Singapore and Canada, among other countries, author Mehran Gul said China today “is the only competitor” against the US.

“Others are trying, but they’re not good enough to be dangerous”, Gul – winner of the Financial Times/McKinsey Bracken Bower Prize, who previously covered tech topics for the World Economic Forum and the United Nations – said in his book.

“The rise of DeepSeek and China’s open-source AI models, such as Alibaba’s Qwen, have proved that China’s AI research is strong”, Gul said in an interview.

In September, DeepSeek’s landmark peer-reviewed article on its R1 reasoning model was published by the British journal Nature, marking a significant leap for China’s AI community. Meanwhile, Alibaba Group Holding’s Qwen family is powering the world’s top 10 open-source large language models (LLMs), according to AI developer platform Hugging Face.

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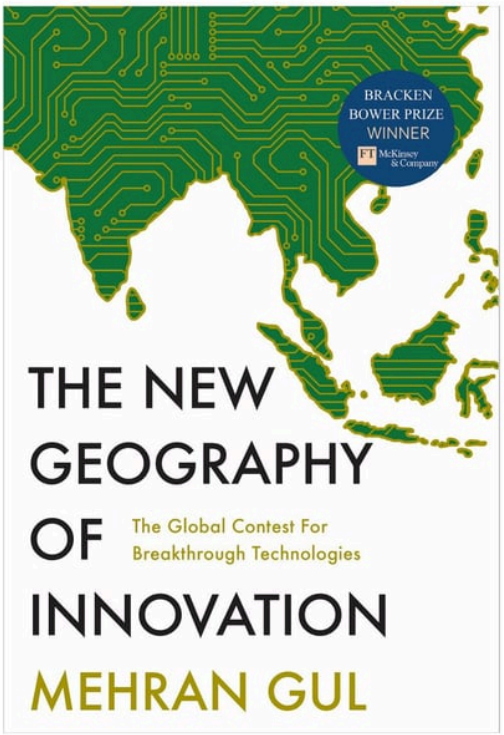


The New Geography of Innovation maps the rise of new tech powers around the world. Photo: Handout

Gul said start-ups in developed countries “tend to rely overwhelmingly on Chinese models”. For example, a partner at venture capital Andreessen Horowitz, also known as a16z, had 80 per cent of his portfolio companies using foundation models from China, Gul said.

“The open source lead can in the future translate into a platform lock-in where companies both in the US and other countries are much more used to working with Chinese models”, he said. “In that one important respect, China does have a lead already that can widen over time.”

Talent is one of the most critical advantages China has, Gul said. However, “it’s still very aspirational for the top-tier Chinese talent to work for American companies or universities”, he added. “And that has not really changed in a substantial way other than people who are nearing retirement or at later stages of their career [returning to China].”

In 2022, 47 per cent of the world’s top AI researchers were from China, but only 12 per cent worked in the country, the second biggest destination after the US, which attracted 57 per cent of them, according to think tank MacroPolo, which ceased operations in March.

But this represented significant progress because in 2019 China was not in the top five in terms of retaining the best AI talent worldwide, according to MacroPolo data.

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“The bigger question over here is how China would attract non-Chinese talent,” Gul said. “This is where the US really stands apart from China. The US doesn’t rely solely on American talent, but it’s getting people from all over the world, including its primary adversaries.”

In his book, Gul looked at several other countries with strong immigrant societies, such as Canada, Switzerland and Singapore, comparing them to a time when the US had turned hostile against foreign workers. In late September, US President Donald Trump signed an executive action to impose a US$100,000 application fee for H-1B visas, which allowed American companies to sponsor foreign workers with specialised skills, such as scientists, engineers and computer programmers.

The abrupt policy change triggered panic among H-1B holders from China, some of whom abandoned plans to travel outside the US.

“Other countries that have a friendlier immigrant policy are already seeing advancement in AI research. One of the biggest advances in AI in the past decade, AlexNet, came from Canada”, Gul said, adding that Canada had “as strong an edge as China” in AI research.

Amid the rise of China, Washington has imposed widespread sanctions against Chinese companies, including export controls on advanced chips.

Gul said that the policies “have not worked as well as intended in holding back China’s technological advancement”. He cited Huawei Technologies as an example.

Despite restrictions on its access to the US market and technology, Huawei was “still a very successful and innovative company, with its advancements in foldable phones, AI computing and chips”, Gul said.

In September, Huawei claimed to have developed the “world’s most powerful” supernode computing cluster using domestic chips.

That was why “the US is recalibrating policies”, Gul said. “Instead of banning access to all Nvidia chips, it offers some access because at least that ensures that China doesn’t go out and build its own alternatives”.

Still, Beijing launched an investigation into alleged security risks of Nvidia’s H20 chips after the US resumed export of the product. Nvidia has repeatedly said that the chips do not have any back doors.

The Chinese version of Gul’s book will be released in 2026. He has also signed publishing deals in the US, UK, Japan, South Korea and Russia.

Coco Feng

Coco Feng joined the Post in 2019, covering the technology and internet sector from the Greater Bay Area. Previously, she worked at the Post's Beijing bureau.